Ludvig Holberg (1684–1754)

Setting the Stage

PHI 423 | The Modern Breakthrough in Scandinavia

A man between two worlds

- Born Bergen, Norway (1684); died Copenhagen (1754)
- Spent his career at the University of Copenhagen — professor of metaphysics, then rhetoric, then history
- A European intellectual: Oxford, Paris, Rome, Hamburg
- Founder of modern Danish-Norwegian literature and theatre
- *Also* a systematic moral and political philosopher

The philosophical work

Introduction til Naturens og Folke-Rettens Kundskab (1716) Natural law freed from theology; required reading for Danish law students until 1936

Moralske Tanker (1744) 63 Montaigne-style essays — ironic, paradoxical, anti-dogmatic

Epistler (1748–54) Philosophy in a conversational register; four volumes

Niels Klim (1741) Utopian satire — European customs defamiliarised from underground

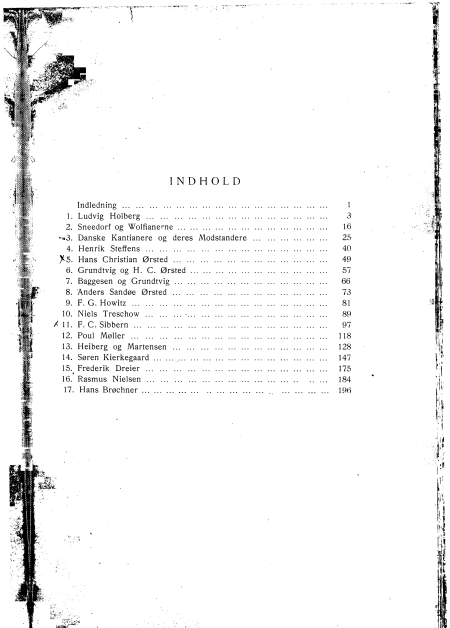
Holberg's intellectual position

- **Empiricist**: knowledge grounded in experience; follows Locke and the English tradition he absorbed at Oxford
- **Anti-systematic**: eclectic by principle, suspicious of grand metaphysical architectures
- **Natural law moralist**: ethics grounded in reason and social utility, not revealed religion
- **Deist**: critical of pietism and revealed theology, but not irreligious

Holberg in the Danish philosophical tradition

Harald Høffding's *Danske Filosoffer* (1909) surveys the history of philosophy in Denmark and Norway.

Holberg is **Chapter 1** — the founding figure from whom the whole tradition flows.



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Why Holberg matters for this course

He sets the tone for the tradition we are studying.

- Høffding calls him the first Danish philosopher to engage *independently* with the problems of thought — "den første herhjemme, der på selvstændig måde tager stilling til tankens problemer"
- Aall: Holberg is the founder of *den dansk-norske individualisme* — resistance to German system-philosophy, insistence on experience
- Allen: Holberg is Kierkegaard's unacknowledged mentor — irony, indirect communication, the ridicule of pedantry and crowd-conformism

Erasmus Montanus (1723)

The paradigm case of Holbergian satire:

- Rasmus Berg returns from Copenhagen as "Erasmus Montanus"
- Armed with syllogisms, he proves the earth is round — and that his mother is a stone
- The village sees him as arrogant and dangerous; he recants to marry and be left in peace

What is Holberg satirising — the pedant, or the crowd? Or both?

The thread to follow

Holberg establishes a philosophical style:

concrete, ironic, anti-systematic, morally serious.

This style — not any specific doctrine — is what gets transmitted to Kierkegaard, Brandes, and the Modern Breakthrough writers.